



GOLD BULL'S HEAD WITH SHELL INLAY

▶ c.3000–330 BCE

ANCIENT EGYPTIAN

The Ancient Egyptians filled elaborate tombs inside pyramids with statues, painted mummy cases, frescoes, and picture scrolls to help the dead in their afterlife. Painters had to show complete human forms so every figure combines a front and side view.



MODEL OF A GRANARY



TOMB PAINTING



RITUAL WATER JAR



HIGHLY DECORATED TOMB FIGURES



▶ c.2000–146 BCE

ANCIENT GREEK

The earliest frescoes and pottery, found in a Minoan palace on the island of Crete, are painted with colourful scenes of everyday life. Temples in Ancient Greece were decorated with marble friezes showing processions and beautifully carved columns.



FRESCO OF A LEAPING BULL



DORIC, IONIC, AND CORINTHIAN COLUMNS



DECORATIVE VASE

◀ c.650 BCE–1900 CE



HINDU TEMPLE, INDIA

EASTERN

For more than 2,000 years, artists from India, China, and Japan have created beautiful objects using stone, ceramics, precious stones, and metals. Colourful Indian temples were lavishly decorated with figures of gods and goddesses. Serene Japanese prints on silk and parchment were known as "pictures of the floating world".



HOKUSAI PRINT, JAPAN



STONEWARE LION, MING DYNASTY, CHINA



HEAD OF THE BUDDHA, JAPAN



ORNATE FIGURE OF AN ELEPHANT, CHINA

◀ c.750 BCE–476 CE

ANCIENT ROMAN

Statues and busts (just the head) of emperors, famous people from the past, and gods and goddesses were popular in Ancient Rome. Wealthy people had gold jewellery, decorated pottery, and ornate glassware. The finest houses were decorated with mosaic floors and panels, and painted frescoes.



TERRACOTTA (CLAY) BUST



BEWARE OF THE DOG MOSAIC, POMPEII



FRESCO ON VILLA WALL, POMPEII

▶ 1880–1905



MONET'S GARDEN
Monet's paintings of his lily ponds captured changes in the light and seasons.



MURAL INSPIRED BY VAN GOGH'S THE STARRY NIGHT

POST-IMPRESSIONISM

Painting got bolder, brighter, and freer in this period. Vincent Van Gogh poured his feelings into swirling landscapes created with thick brushstrokes and heavy paint. Others developed new techniques. Seurat's pointillist pictures were painted with millions of tiny dots of colour that blended together.



FIGURE BY RODIN
Rodin produced life-like figures that portrayed powerful emotions.

NATURAL LIGHT
Using new portable easels and tubes of paint, artists left their studio to paint outdoors.

▶ c.1900–1950

EXPRESSIONISM AND SURREALISM

Expressionist painters used vivid colours and stark images, often squeezing the paint straight from the tube on to the canvas. Their pictures were not intended to show real life but express their personalities. Surrealist art turned the world upside down. Artists produced dream-like paintings and absurd objects like furry teacups and spiky irons.

"IF YOU UNDERSTAND A PAINTING BEFOREHAND YOU MIGHT AS WELL NOT PAINT IT"

SALVADOR DALI, SURREALIST ARTIST

▶ 1907–1960s

MODERN ART

Cubism was the beginning of modern art. Leading artist Picasso created startling figures with angular shapes that broke all the rules about colour, form, and perspective. Many years later in the United States, abstract expressionist artists invented action painting – splashing, smearing, or dribbling paint onto the canvas.



INSPIRED BY JACKSON POLLOCK

▶ 1970s–PRESENT

CONTEMPORARY

In contemporary art, anything goes. Painters use styles from the past and often rework and mix them together to show new ideas. Art can take many different forms. It can be a shed blown apart with all its pieces suspended in midair; a skull studded with diamonds; or lonely figures perched on buildings across a city skyline.



ANTONY GORMLEY'S EVENT HORIZON



MILLENNIUM PARK FOUNTAIN, CHICAGO